

The Neta as Human Being

One of the most popular and prolific content creators on YouTube, BeerBiceps aka Ranveer Allahbadia started out nine years ago focusing on health and fitness. These days, on "The Ranveer Show" he looks to draw the Gen Z audience which doesn't read print news and watch TV news and tries to bring the "human side of politicians" with questions like "What's the most pissed off you've gotten at one of these [international] meetings?", as posed to external affairs minister S. Jaishankar.

"I'm not trying to blow my own trumpet but personality is a big

RANVEER ALLAHBADIA AKA BEERBICEPS

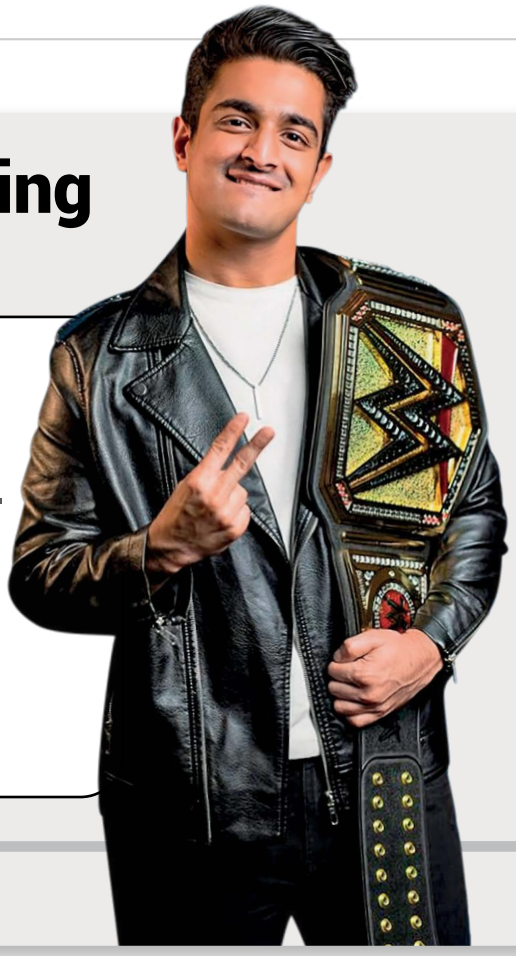
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Based in MUMBAI

SUBSCRIBERS

BeerBiceps
7.42 million

Ranveer Allahbadia
8.03 million



tions that bind traditional media outlets and free of the burden of neutrality, they have emerged as powerful voices that cut through the clutter and provide a clear view on events. And Indian elections are a rich field to mine, from Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal's guilt or otherwise in the excise policy case, which political party benefitted the most from electoral bonds or Rahul Gandhi's competence as a leader.

Their approach varies. Some use a direct, explanatory style to talk about relevant issues like farmers' protests, corruption and the Ram Mandir; others opt for a candid interview format, showcasing a lesser-seen, lighter side of a politician or use satire to highlight the absurdity of it all in YouTube shorts or Insta reels. Such is their impact that the Government of India recognised their growing clout and instituted the National Creator Awards just before the election, in which the PM felicitated creators such as Abhi and Niyu, BeerBiceps, Curly Tales aka Kamiya Jani, Technical Guruji aka Gaurav Chaudhary among others. "You are the digital ambassadors of India all over the world," PM Modi said to the audience at the event held at New Delhi's Bharat Mandapam in March. "You are the brand ambassadors of Vocal for Local... MVPs of the internet." It could be financially profitable too for the influencers - estimates by American social media analytics website Social Blade indicate the earnings of these influencers could be upwards of $55,000 annually.

INTERVIEWS WITH INFLUENCERS ARE LESS FORMAL, ALLOWING POLITICIANS TO PRESENT A DIFFERENT IMAGE OF THEMSELVES

STREAMERS WITH SWAY

Nearly 60 per cent of India's 1.4 billion population has access to the internet and at least 462 million of them use YouTube, according to Statista (an advanced analytics software package), making us a country with the largest audience for the social media video platform. The Reuters' Digital News Report of 2023 found that when it comes to consuming news online, around four in 10 Indians preferred to watch news online rather than read it. It also noted that YouTube topped WhatsApp and Facebook as the preferred social media tool for news. It's no surprise then that everyone from Trinamool Congress leader Ma-